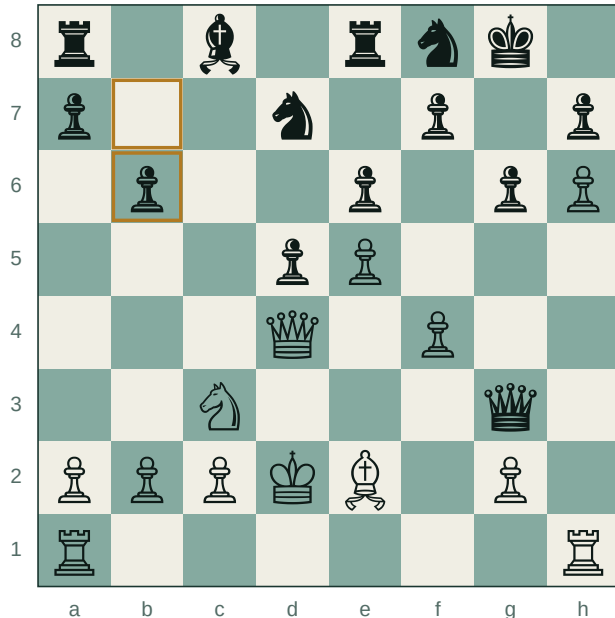


Trapping a piece: White, move 19

Trapping a piece

White to move



Previous move: 18...b6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

19. Bf3 Ba6 20. Rh3 Qxh3 21. gxh3

19.Bf3 The bishop moves from e2 to f3. Recorded reply: **19...Ba6**.

20.Rh3 The rook moves from h1 to h3. Recorded reply: **20...Qxh3**.

21.gxh3 The pawn captures the queen on h3.

At the end, nominal material is White 27 / Black 26 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +4: the balance goes from -3 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: rook on e8 and rook on a8. Check for tactical protection.